Guidance Snapshot for Patients

U.S. FOOD & DRUG ADMINISTRATION

Enhancing the Diversity of Clinical Trial Populations — Eligibility Criteria, Enrollment Practices, and Trial Designs

Final Guidance

Why is this guidance important for patients?

Clinical trials (or trials) test potential treatments in human volunteers to see whether they should be approved for wider use in the general population. Participants of a clinical trial should be similar to the population that will ultimately use the drug or biologic, if approved by FDA. This guidance offers recommendations for enhancing the diversity of clinical trial participants to ensure the drug or biologic product's safety and effectiveness in a wide range of populations.

The guidance provides recommendations for the following:

- Broadening the eligibility criteria for participating in trials and avoiding unnecessary exclusions
- Designing trials to be accessible to more people
- Improving the recruitment of participants in trials while maintaining the safety and effectiveness standards
- Applying the recommendations to trials of drugs and biologics for rare diseases or conditions

What is recommended in the guidance?

This guidance recommends approaches that clinical trial sponsors can use to include the following people in the trials of drugs and biologics (examples: vaccines, gene therapy):

- People who differ by their population-related (demographic) characteristics, such as sex, race, ethnicity, or age.
- People who differ by their nondemographic characteristics, such as having problems with internal organs (such as kidney or liver), other existing diseases (comorbidities), disabilities; those at the extremes of weight range; and populations with rare or less widespread diseases or conditions.

Why did FDA issue this guidance?

The FDA is committed to promoting practices that improve enrollment of populations underrepresented in trials. Despite these efforts, certain groups continue to be underrepresented. This guidance offers sponsors* of clinical trials detailed recommendations for increasing enrollment of underrepresented populations, including those with rare diseases.

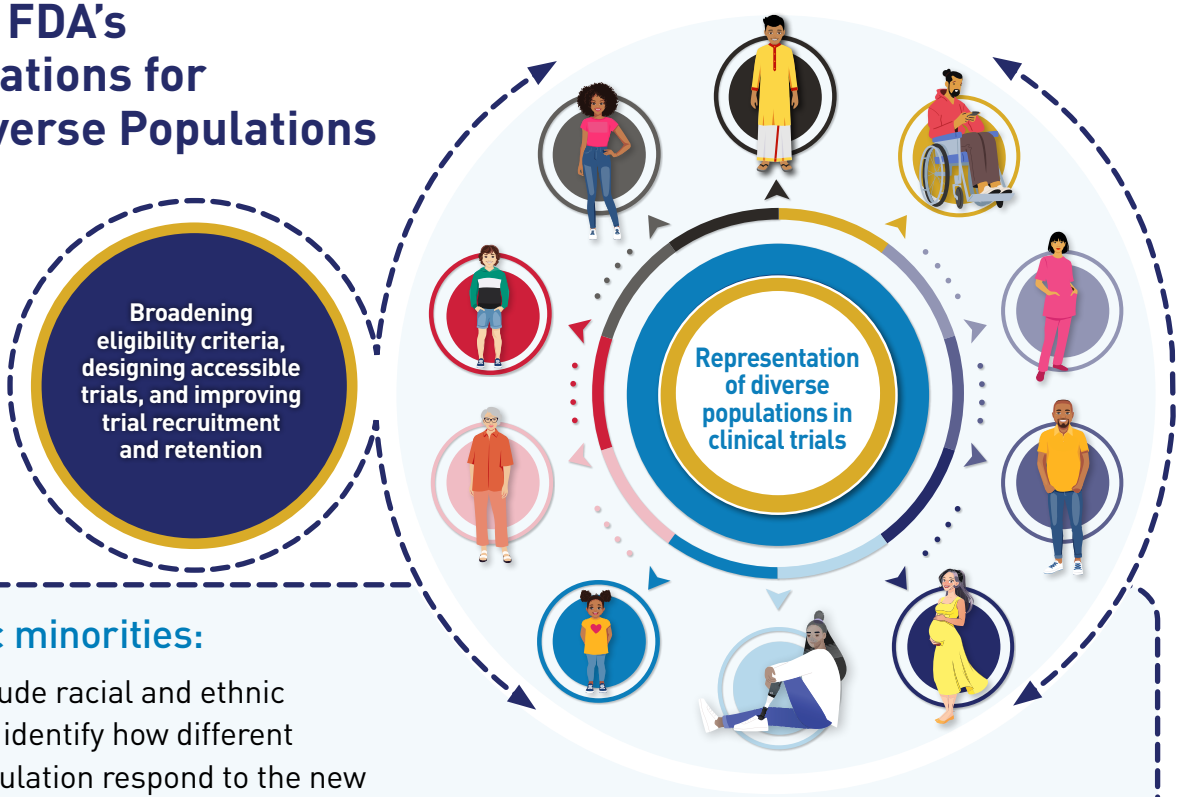
*Sponsor means a person who takes responsibility for and initiates a clinical investigation. The sponsor may be an individual or pharmaceutical company, governmental agency, academic institution, private organization, or other organization, etc.

Guidance documents explain FDA's current thinking on a topic. Guidance Snapshots are a communication tool and are not a substitute for the guidance document. To learn more about enhancing the diversity of clinical trials, read the guidance.

What are eligibility criteria?

Eligibility criteria are the requirements a participant must meet to enter a clinical trial. The criteria are determined for each study and may include such characteristics as age, sex, gender, medical history, current health status, and absence of diseases. One objective of eligibility criteria is to exclude people for whom the risk of an adverse event (a medical problem associated with a drug or biologic product) outweighs both the individual's potential benefit from participating in the trial and the importance of the knowledge expected to be gained from the trial.

Examples of FDA's Recommendations for Enrolling Diverse Populations



Racial and ethnic minorities:

Sponsors should include racial and ethnic minorities in trials to identify how different subgroups of the population respond to the new drug or biologic.

Children and adolescents:

When appropriate, sponsors should include children and adolescents in confirmatory clinical trials involving adults. Sponsors should consider a broader pediatric development program early in drug development. The sponsor's plan to enroll pediatric patients should be based on a clear scientific rationale.

Females:

Sponsors should include females in clinical trials in adequate numbers to allow for analysis by sex. In clinical trials for most drugs and biologics, including representatives of both sexes in adequate numbers allows for the detection of clinically significant sex-related differences in response.

Pregnant participants:

When possible, sponsors should consider including pharmacokinetic sampling to establish dosing in women who become pregnant during a trial. The information gathered from such testing allows sponsors to ensure safe and continued participation of pregnant individuals, taking into consideration the individuals' risks and anticipated benefits.

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How can sponsors make clinical trial enrollment and retention practices more inclusive?

EDUCATE

Educate participants about clinical trial participation.

ENGAGE

Engage medical societies, focus groups, community advisory boards, and disease registries in order to more effectively meet the needs of potential participants.

RECRUIT

- Hold recruitment events frequently and offer them during evenings and weekends. Sponsors can hold events in nonclinical but trusted locations, such as places of worship or community centers; social places of business, such as barbershops and beauty salons; and public gatherings, such as cultural festivals, carnivals, and parades.
- Use online/social media platforms to identify participants for whom traditional referral centers are not accessible.

BE CULTURALLY SENSITIVE

- Provide cultural competency and proficiency training to clinical investigators and research staff so that they can build trusting relationships with participants.
- Avoid the use of cultural generalizations and stereotypes in interactions with participants.
- Share trial resources and documents in multiple languages; use multilingual research staff and/or interpreters for participants with limited English comprehension.

GET FEEDBACK

Ask for patients' feedback; they may provide valuable insight into challenges and burdens and may be more willing to accept risk for a potential benefit from participation or to learn more about their disease.

MAINTAIN RELATIONSHIP

Remain engaged with participants and their communities after the clinical trial ends; share clinical trial updates to maintain and strengthen relationships with communities.

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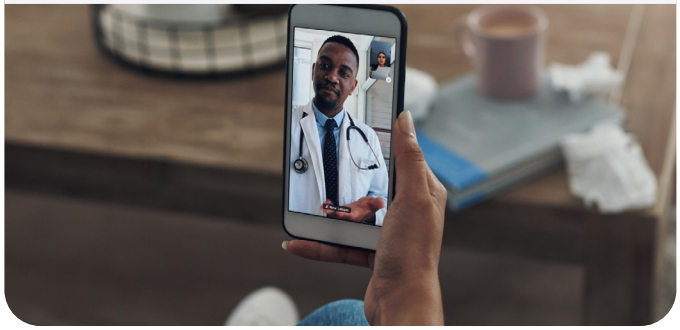
How can sponsors make clinical trials less burdensome for participants?

- Consider flexibilities in visit times and reduce the frequency of in-person study visits, if possible.
- Enlist mobile medical professionals, such as nurses and blood collection workers (phlebotomists), to visit participants at home instead of requiring participants to visit distant clinical trial sites.
- Replace visits to clinical trial sites with electronic communication tools and devices, such as telephones, mobile phones, secured email, social media platforms, or digital health technologies if feasible.
- Inform participants of possible reimbursements for travel, lodging, and costs associated with participation in trials.

How can sponsors make clinical trials for rare diseases more diverse?

- Early in the drug or biologic development process, engage with patient advocacy groups, experts in the rare disease, and patients with the rare disease; ask for their suggestions on the design of trials, including trial procedures.
- After early-phase studies, when medically appropriate and scientifically sound, include participants from earlier-phase clinical trials in the longer-term studies to ensure that participants have access to the drug or biologic if they tolerate it. For example, consider including those who received placebo (any treatment that has no active treatment properties, such as a sugar pill, used for comparison) in the earlier trials to receive the study drug or biologic in the longer-term study.



Guidance Recap Podcast - Hear Highlights Straight from FDA Staff

Speaker: **Atasi Poddar, PhD, Health Science Policy Analyst, Office of Medical Policy**

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